Lech Lecha: The Beginnings of Z'chut Avot

A Turning Point in Torah

This week's parsha marks a turning point in the Torah's story. Until now, Bereishis has been about *humanity*. With *Lech Lecha*, Hashem turns His attention to one man, and through Avram, the story of the *Avos* begins which eventually leads to us.

The Meaning of Z'chus Avos

We often speak about *z'chus Avos*, the merit of our forefathers, as if it is something automatically inherited, a spiritual trust fund that protects us through life. But *z'chus Avos* is not just an unearned reward. It is a *connection*. It means we have access to the same inner strength, the same faith, the same courage that they lived by. To benefit from their *z'chus*, we must also continue their path. But also, to continue their path, we need to understand what they did which applies to us which can help us access the z'chus.

Before Lech Lecha: The Fire of Faith

To understand who Avram truly was, we must step back to the end of *Parshas Noach*. That's where the Midrash first introduces him - a young man who destroyed his father's idols, who challenged the world's beliefs, who was thrown into Nimrod's fiery furnace and emerged alive. Even before Hashem spoke to him directly, Avram was already living a life of faith. He didn't wait to be chosen; he *chose* Hashem first.

The Command to Go

When Hashem finally tells him, *Lech lecha mei'artzecha* - leave your land, your birthplace, your father's house, Avram had already left *Ur Kasdim* and was in *Charan*. So why tell him to go again? Chazal explain that this was not about distance, but about depth. The first journey was physical; the second was spiritual. "Go *for yourself*," says Hashem, not to escape the past, but to uncover your essence. Growth is never just about leaving; it is about becoming.

From that moment, Avram's life becomes a series of journeys, each one testing his faith and refining his soul. He leaves behind familiarity and comfort. He faces famine and descends to Egypt. He risks his life to rescue Lot. Each time, he moves forward, not backward. Each time, he discovers a new dimension of *emunah* - a faith that does not depend on comfort or certainty.

The Fear in Egypt - Seeing the Best in Others

One puzzling moment stands out: when Avram tells Sarai, *"Please say you're my sister."* How could the man who survived being put into a fiery furnace fear for his life? The *mefarshim* explain that Avram did not doubt Hashem's power, he doubted his *worthiness*. Perhaps he thought he had already used up his miracles. And yet, even in fear, he acted with faith, protecting his wife and trusting Hashem to do what was right.

There is a deeper beauty here. The Midrash says that just as Avram trusted that Sarai would be saved through her own righteousness, Sarai trusted that Avram would be saved through his. Each believed in the other more than in themselves. Avram and Sarai lived that balance. They looked outward with love and inward with honesty. The Lubavitcher Rebbe taught that people will often look at others with the *right eye*, with kindness and generosity, and at themselves with the *left eye*, with stringency, which may have been what Avram and Sarai at that point in time were doing. But a way that we can heal over time as well is to learn to look at ourselves and others with both eyes in a fair and balanced way which we can see as they both see their own value more and more throught the coming parshiot.

The Courage to Risk for Others

Later, when Avram fought the war of the kings to rescue Lot, we see his truer colors start to come out as he risks himself for others, guided not by self-interest but by conscience. That is *Lech Lecha* in its purest form, to go *to yourself*, to go *beyond yourself*, and to go *for yourself*. It is a journey of constant growth, of never being satisfied with who we were yesterday.

Beyond the Stars

Life brings us tests. It asks us to step into the unknown, to leave behind what feels safe. But that's precisely where growth happens. When Hashem took Avram "outside," showing him the stars and saying, *"Look toward the heavens… so shall your children be,"* He was teaching him that faith itself must rise above nature. Avram could not have children according to the stars, so Hashem lifted him *beyond* them. He didn't just change Avram's fate; He changed the very definition of faith.

The Midrashim say and the Mepharshim explain that Hashem took Avram out of this world and past the stars that exist. He said that just because you are right now Avram and your wife is Sarai doesn't mean that you will always have to be that way. Avram had the courage to follow through with his *emunah* in Hashem and His promises, to change himself so that he would be continuously going out to himself and out to others together. This is the lesson we bring from Avram Avinu, not even from Avraham, but from Avram. In our earliest stages, we can already start to change who we are, what our reality is, what our direction and purpose are. And then as we, their legacy, live forward this way, we get to tap into *z'chus avos*.

Personal Reflection

My own life, in its own humble way, echoes a lot of this message. I grew up in California, far from the life I live today. Through challenges, moves, and changes, I found myself learning Torah in Baltimore, and ultimately, *Baruch Hashem*, here in Eretz Yisrael. Each transition came with uncertainty, often not generated by want but rather a push from something bigger and greater than myself, but also with the quiet voice of *Lech Lecha*. Move forward, keep growing, trust the process. Looking back, I can see how each step, even the difficult ones, was guided by Hashem's hand and has helped me to develop who I am today, someone who, like Avraham Avinue, went out not just to himself but for others as well.

Our Living Legacy

Avram and Sarai began as a couple who could not have children. Yet today, we - their descendants - are the proof of what faith can create. We are their living legacy, the continuation of that moment when Hashem said, "Look up."

The Call of Lech Lecha

As we enter Shabbos Lech Lecha, we can all hear that same call: *Lech lecha* - go forward. Step out of what's familiar. Not because we're unworthy, but because we are *worthy* of growing further. Like Avram, we too are invited to move beyond the limits of nature, beyond the stories we tell ourselves, and to walk toward the person Hashem knows we can become.

A Few Questions for Self-Reflection

- How am I going out of myself to grow?
- Am I standing up for what is right?
- Am I looking at myself and others in a way of *dan l'zchus*?